

The Bridge

(Season 3 Episode 1, 2015)

Section A: Television in the Global Age (A Level)

Focus Areas:

- Media Language
- Representation
- Media Industries
- Audiences
- Media contexts

PRODUCT CONTEXT

- *The Bridge* (*Bron/Broen*) is one of the A Level options studied for Section A: Television in the Global Age alongside *Life on Mars*. The set product is the first episode of Series 3 which was broadcast in the UK on BBC Four at 9pm on 21st November 2015.
- *The Bridge* is an example of a Scandinavian sub-genre of crime drama – Nordic Noir. The drama is set in Sweden, the title refers to the Oresund Bridge between Denmark and Sweden and is a metaphor for the collaboration between the two police forces which commenced after a body was discovered in the middle of the bridge in the first episode of the first series.
- The crime drama was a co-production between Filmance International and Nimbus Film.
- *The Bridge* followed on from the success of other Nordic Noir crime dramas broadcast by BBC Four including the highly successful *The Killing* and *Wallander*. There were four series between 2011-2018.
- Series 3 opens with the murder in Malmo of a prominent Danish gender campaigner and owner of Copenhagen's first gender neutral pre-school. Swedish detective Saga Norén is assigned a new Danish colleague Hanne to help with the investigation, but their relationship does not get off to a good start with feelings still running high after Saga's involvement in sending her previous Danish partner Martin to jail for murdering the man who killed his son.

PART 1: STARTING POINTS – Media Language

The codes and conventions of media forms and products, including the processes through which media language develops as a genre.

- In its simplest terms a genre is a type of media product, but it is more complex than that and also provides a way for producers to communicate messages to audiences. Audiences need to be able to recognise genres and the codes and conventions are established over time. The audience have expectations regarding genres and establishing the genre is key to the effective marketing of the product.
- Crime dramas have a recognisable repertoire of elements, these may be specific to a sub-genre, for example a psychological crime drama. These conventions have evolved over time and developed to reflect social and cultural change and the needs and expectations of audiences. However, these dramas share similarities which place them in the crime genre including:
- **Narrative:** this is usually based on a crime that needs to be investigated and solved.
 - Structure. Crime dramas may use a range of different narrative structures. They may conform to Todorov's theory where the structure is linear from the initial disruption through to a resolution, or non-linear where time and space is manipulated. Inverted narratives show the crime and the perpetrator at the start and then may have a non-linear structure including flashbacks. Other examples of the genre create a restricted narrative in which information is withheld from the audience and they are involved in solving of the crime alongside the police. In *The Bridge* there are elements of a flexi-narrative. The characters are complex, storylines interweave, and the audience is challenged through enigma and engagement with complex characters.
 - Narrative disruptions occur that change the course of the story, these can be events that happen or revelations that are made by characters. Sometimes the audience are in a privileged spectator position whereby they